

"When we own up our mistakes some people interpret it as if we are wrong. They too commit mistakes."

THE PRAGMATIST

He preserved the democratic spirit within the Communist Party, inspired the movement that made Kerala India's first fully literate state and rewrote its social equations by uprooting feudalism

■ By P. Govinda Pillai

Despite world wars, fascism, genocides and predatory capitalism, 20th century's defining hallmark was the spirit of freedom and the triumph of democracy. Communism also was proved unsustainable if it refused to recognise the significance of individual freedom, democracy and dissent. Perhaps the Indian communists'

greatest contribution in the last century was the lesson they provided on functioning within a democratic system even as they maintained its Marxist-Leninist core. Much before the world's communist parties began their problematic engagement with democracy, the Communist Party of

India (CPI) had begun this tryst, right after Independence.

In many ways, Elamkulam Manakkal Sankaran Namboodiripad personifies Indian communism's tryst with democracy. In 1957 he created history by becoming India's first communist chief minister heading the

E.M.S. Namboodiripad

Communist leader 1909-1998

